The women of that land
Are of such delectable beauty
One could slay a hundred Firangis
With the power of her buttocks'[57]

This was apparently not just the fertile imagination of the Maulana at work – Masson also notes with some anxiety that Burnes had shown far more interest in the women of Kabul than was wise, especially for an accredited diplomat. Masson wrote that the Amir was kept updated on Burnes's 'revels' with what Maulana Kashmiri calls 'the delectable houris of Kabul' and 'rejoiced perhaps that the envoy's intrigues were of any other than of a political nature'. Masson records that, because of Burnes's appetites, before long he received a visit from Mirza Sami Khan, Dost Mohammad's Minister, who 'proposed I should imitate the example of my illustrious superior, and fill my house with black-eyed damsels. I observed that my house was hardly large enough, and anyway where were the damsels to come from? He replied that I might select any I pleased, and he would take care I should have them. I told him his charity exceeded all praise, but I thought it better to go on quietly in my old ways.'[58]

This was not Masson's only anxiety. It was not just that Burnes's behaviour lacked the 'decorum . . . [with which] it was supposed that a British mission would be conducted', he was worried by Burnes's diplomatic instincts and feared that his manner with the Amir was too 'compliant and obsequious', that he was overdoing the flattery, 'prefacing his remarks with Garib Nawaz, your humble petitioner'.[59] Masson was also concerned that Burnes was encouraging the Amir to hope for the full restoration of Peshawar through British mediation, when it was still far from certain that Ranjit Singh would be at all amenable to this, or that Calcutta would be prepared to press him on that matter, or even that the young Ambassador had the authority to conduct such negotiations in the first place.

Nevertheless, only ten days after his arrival in Kabul, Burnes set out for a quick break in the Afghan countryside, full of optimism about his mission and in the highest spirits. 'A vast vista of gardens extended for some thirty or forty miles in length terminated by the Hindoo Koosh, white with snow,' he wrote happily from the Shomali Plain the following day, exhilarated to be travelling again in the landscape he loved. 'Every hill with a southern aspect had a vineyard on it.'